

Orbital

Live Aircraft, Ship and Satellite Tracking — Project Report

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Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Background and Problem Statement

At any moment roughly fourteen thousand aircraft are in the air, tens of thousands of ships are at sea, and thousands of satellites are in orbit. Almost all of them broadcast their position. Aircraft transmit ADS-B, ships transmit AIS, and satellite orbits are published as orbital elements. The data is public and free to collect.

It is difficult to use. Four problems stand in the way.

The raw formats cannot be displayed as received. ADS-B reports altitude in feet and speed in knots. AIS encodes “not available” as a number inside the valid range, so a vessel with no speed reading transmits 102.3 knots. Orbital elements are a text format that must be run through a physics model before it means a position.

Every free source is incomplete, in different places. Measured on identical areas, OpenSky reported 22 aircraft over Myanmar where adsb.lol reported 4; adsb.lol reported 33 over inland China where OpenSky reported none.

Free access is metered. OpenSky bills by area against a daily allowance. adsb.lol permits four requests then roughly one every twelve seconds. Naive polling exhausts either within hours.

Commercial alternatives are closed. MarineTraffic, FleetMon and Spire are now owned by Kpler; ORBCOMM’s AIS business by S&P Global.

Problem statement. Public position data for aircraft, ships and satellites is abundant and free, but fragmented across sources with different formats, different coverage gaps and different access limits. No free tool presents all three on one map while being explicit about what it does not know.

1.2 Project Objectives

Objective

- 01 Present live aircraft positions on an interactive Earth in a browser
- 02 Isolate the browser from every external data source
- 03 Survive upstream failure without breaking the display
- 04 Normalise every source onto one shared data shape
- 05 Extend the same architecture to satellites and ships
- 06 Provide user accounts and a differentiated service tier
- 07 Record the reasoning behind every significant decision

05 exists to test whether the abstraction in 04 is real or accidental.

1.3 Project Scope

In scope

Area	Included
Aircraft	Live positions from two sources, merged; flight track; airline and type; airport search; receiver coverage
Satellites	~1,400 satellites computed from orbital elements; orbit class
Ships	~23,000 vessels from two sources, merged; type, dimensions, destination, status
Solar system	Eight planets and the Moon, navigable
Accounts	Registration, sign-in, sessions, three tiers
Time travel	Historical satellite positions, limited by tier

Out of scope

Excluded	Reason
Space debris and rocket bodies	The catalogue holds ~100,000 objects, most not worth drawing
Collision or re-entry prediction	The model is accurate to kilometres; a viewer could not detect a wrong answer
A fourth object class	Requires a written decision; enforced by a test on each side
Ground-station passes	Feasible but outside the objectives
Flight or voyage prediction	Orbital reports observations, it does not forecast

1.4 Expected Benefits

For viewers. One free view of aircraft, ships and satellites, with no account required and no claim of completeness the data cannot support. Markers older than two minutes fade. The ship layer is labelled “ships in coastal waters” because both AIS feeds are received from the shore.

For data providers. One backend makes a fixed number of requests regardless of how many people are watching, polling each source at the rate that source asks for.

For the team. A worked example of a system with three interchangeable data layers, where the interchangeability was tested twice by adding a layer. Each new layer cost one provider module and one registry entry.

1.5 Tools and Technologies Used

Layer	Technology	Reason
Map	MapLibre GL JS	One continuous view from globe to street level on real imagery

3D models	three.js	Draws the selected aircraft inside MapLibre's WebGL context
Frontend	React, TypeScript, Vite	Contract enforced at compile time
Backend	FastAPI, Python	Pydantic makes the same contract executable
HTTP	httpx	Async, so polling never blocks a request
WebSocket	websockets	The global AIS feed pushes rather than answers
Storage	In-process memory; SQLite for accounts	One process, one poller; accounts are the only state that must survive a restart
Orbits	sgp4	The standard propagator for the published element format
Tests	pytest, Vitest	Both run offline against fixture data

Data sources

Source	Provides	Access
adsb.lol	Aircraft	Open Database Licence, no key
OpenSky Network	Aircraft	Free, non-commercial, OAuth2, metered
Digitraffic (Fintraffic)	Ships, Baltic	CC BY 4.0, commercial permitted, no key
aisstream.io	Ships, global	Free, key required
CelesTrak / SatNOGS	Orbital elements	Free
NASA GIBS, OpenFreeMap	Imagery and map tiles	Open

1.6 Scale of the System

Measure	Value
Backend	~19,100 lines, 85 files
Frontend	~28,500 lines, 159 files
Automated tests	1,842 (823 backend, 1,019 frontend)
HTTP endpoints	16
Recorded decisions	166
Objects served	13,829 aircraft, 23,297 ships, 1,431 satellites

Chapter 2: Feasibility Study and Related Work

2.1 Technical Feasibility

Every claim below was tested against the live services before the design depended on it.

Question	Result
Are live aircraft positions obtainable without payment?	Yes. OpenSky returned 11,651 worldwide; adsb.lol 10,009
Can the whole world be fetched economically?	Yes. 10,013 aircraft in 1.9 seconds
Can satellite positions be computed rather than fetched?	Yes. ~1,400 satellites, no network in the request path
Are live ship positions obtainable without payment?	Yes. 916 vessels in 37 KB from one request; 17,848 in four minutes from the stream

Two measurements that changed the design

One global query is not enough. A single 6,000 nautical-mile circle returned 10,013 aircraft and four circles returned 10,009, which appeared to prove one was sufficient. The other three sample points were inside the area the first already covered. Over Australia the single circle returned 0 and a direct query returned 27. The global sweep uses four circles.

A rate limit cannot be characterised with a burst. adsb.lol appeared to tolerate any rate when tested with occasional bursts. Under continuous load it refused 38% of requests. The real limit is four requests, then approximately one every twelve seconds.

Performance

The backend runs a single-threaded event loop, so a slow operation delays every other request.

Objects held	Poll apply	Bbox filter	Thin to 2,000	Search
2,000	0.7 ms	0.57 ms	0.82 ms	1.6 ms
10,000	7.4 ms	3.2 ms	9.1 ms	8.3 ms
30,000	14.4 ms	9.2 ms	43.5 ms	24.2 ms

Rendering at the 2,000-marker cap costs 0.80 ms per update, 4.8% of a 60 fps frame budget, scaling linearly to 10,000.

Conclusion: technically feasible. Every required capability was demonstrated on live services before being designed around.

2.2 Economic Feasibility

Direct cost

Category	Cost
Data sources	0
Map imagery and tiles	0
Libraries and tooling	0
Hosting during development	0
Total	0

The real cost is labour: four students over one semester.

The quota is the budget

No money changes hands, but OpenSky's daily credit allowance is finite and was budgeted like money. The polling intervals are derived from it rather than chosen by feel: the configured jobs project 3,072 credits per day against a 4,000 allowance, 77%, leaving headroom for the lookups a user triggers by clicking. The system refuses to start if a configuration would exceed 85%.

Using the free adsb.lol feed as the primary source, with OpenSky supplementing it every 120 seconds, decouples the refresh rate from the allowance entirely. Ships and satellites cost nothing.

Licensing constrains the revenue model

Source	Commercial use
Digitraffic	Permitted (CC BY 4.0)
adsb.lol	Permitted (ODbL)
OpenSky Network	Forbidden, non-commercial only
aisstream.io	Not stated

A commercial version is possible but not with the current source mix: the aircraft layer would have to drop OpenSky and accept its coverage gaps.

The implemented model

A free tier supported by advertising and a paid tier are both implemented. Advertisements are the project's own messages in real advertisement dimensions, because a third-party network would introduce tracking into a project that collects no analytics. There is no payment processor, so the button reads "Switch premium on" rather than "Buy", and a test enforces that wording.

2.3 Operational Feasibility

Operation

Orbital runs as two processes with no database server, no message queue and no external cache. State lives in process memory; only accounts must survive a restart, in one SQLite file.

Failure behaviour

The API layer never calls an upstream service. It reads a cache the ingestion layer fills on a schedule, so there is no upstream call in the request path that can fail.

Failure	Behaviour
Upstream 5xx	Last good snapshot served, flagged stale; poller backs off
Rate limited	Same, using the upstream's own retry hint
One of two feeds down	The other continues; the map is drawn
CelesTrak returned 503 for a full day	The SatNOGS fallback served; cached elements remain usable for days
Network absent	The fixture provider replays committed data

Readability

The interface must not make claims the data cannot support. Markers older than two minutes fade; an object with no transmitted heading is drawn as a disc rather than an arrow pointing north; the ship layer names its actual coverage; and the satellite layer reports no data age, because a computed position does not have one.

2.4 Schedule Feasibility

Work proceeded in phases, each with an explicit boundary, and each session ended with a written handover.

Phase	Delivered
1	Aircraft layer end to end
2	Satellite layer; migration to MapLibre
3	Moon and solar system views
4	Accounts, tiers, advertisements
5	Ship layer, regional then global
6	Performance and defect sweep

The strongest evidence that the schedule held is the cost of the later phases. The satellite layer cost one provider module and one registry entry; the ship layer cost the same four months later; and the polling logic was not modified for either.

Where time was lost: six sessions went to one defect misdiagnosed five times. The cause was structural — one camera serving two pictures at very different scales — and the resolution deleted 376 lines, added 130, and cost no feature.

2.5 Related Systems

System	Covers	Model	Relationship
Flightradar24	Aircraft	Commercial	The reference for a mature tracker; larger network, closed data
MarineTraffic	Ships	Commercial	The shipping equivalent; acquired during this project
OpenSky Network	Aircraft	Research	Used as a source; its non-commercial clause constrains §2.2
adsb.lol	Aircraft	Community	Used as the primary aircraft source
AISHub	Ships	Reciprocal	Rejected: access requires contributing a receiver
N2YO, Heavens-Above	Satellites	Free	Comparable satellite tracking; neither combines classes

Each individual layer is done better elsewhere by organisations with larger networks. What distinguishes Orbital is that three classes of object with three different acquisition models — observed and metered, observed and free, and computed — are presented on one map through one shared data shape.

A deliberate search found no free, global, key-less ship feed equivalent to adsb.lol. An AIS receiver is a real installation rather than a cheap dongle, so volunteer networks operate on reciprocity, and the commercial half of the market has consolidated under two owners.

2.6 Relevant Theories and Technologies

ADS-B. Aircraft broadcast identity, position, altitude and velocity about once a second. Coverage depends on a receiver being in range, which is why oceanic regions are sparse in every terrestrial network.

AIS. Vessels broadcast position every few seconds and identity — name, type, dimensions, destination — every six minutes. Two consequences follow. “Not available” is a number rather than a blank: a speed of 102.3 knots, a course of 360° and a heading of 511 all mean the transmitter did not say. And identity accumulates far more slowly than position: measured at 26.5 static messages per second against 114 position reports, vessel type coverage rose from 3% at thirty seconds to 62% after fifty-four minutes.

SGP4 and orbital elements. Satellite positions are computed from published two-line element sets. Elements describe an orbit rather than a position and stay usable for days, so the layer survives an upstream outage. Accuracy degrades roughly a kilometre per day from epoch, silently: of 1,670 element sets in one live feed, 87 were over a year old and the oldest was from 1975. Anything past seven days is refused.

Map projection. A pixel covers a different ground distance at every zoom and latitude — about 750 m at zoom 7, about 6 m at zoom 14. This arithmetic determines how often the display needs redrawing, and it is why drawing every object at every zoom is neither useful nor affordable.

Signed distance field icons. Marker symbols are stored as distance fields so one silhouette can be tinted per object rather than needing an image per colour. The alpha channel encodes distance rather than coverage, so thin detail dissolves when scaled down; marker artwork is therefore deliberately chunky.

HTTP conditional requests. The polled endpoints use ETags. When the data has not changed the server returns 304 Not Modified before reading its store — no filtering, thinning, serialisation or compression.

Chapter 3: Requirements Analysis

3.1 Stakeholder Analysis

Orbital's stakeholder map has an unusual shape: most of its stakeholders are upstream. The parties with the greatest power over whether the system works are the data providers, none of whom have any relationship with the project.

Upstream — the data providers

Stakeholder	Interest	Power	How the design responds
adsb.lol	That clients do not abuse a donated service	High	One backend, fixed request count regardless of viewers; a gate enforces the measured rate limit
OpenSky Network	Non-commercial use; quota respected	High	Used as a supplement; spending held at 77% of allowance; startup refuses an overspending configuration
Fintraffic	Attribution under CC BY 4.0	Medium	Attributed; polled at the rate its own cache headers ask for
aisstream.io	Not stated	Medium	Used as a free public service and credited; behind a switch that disables it if the project is monetised
CelesTrak / SatNOGS	Not to be polled excessively	Medium	Refreshed every six hours, cached to disk, with a fallback
Volunteer receiver operators	Recognition that coverage is theirs	Low	The map draws where no network reaches

Because the upstream stakeholders hold the power and grant no guarantees, the system is designed so any of them failing degrades the display rather than breaking it. That is a requirement derived from stakeholder analysis rather than a technical preference.

Downstream — the users

Stakeholder	Needs	Power
Anonymous viewer	To look without registering; not to be misled	High, the default user
Registered free user	An identity; recent history	Medium
Premium user	A wider historical window	Medium
Administrator	Account management	Low, one role

The administrator tier exists in the data but has no interface. An account can only be promoted from a terminal on the server, and the public endpoint refuses that tier under all configurations.

The team

Member	ID	Roles
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Phone Sett Paing Kyaw	6708369	Project Manager, Developer
Bhone Pyae Hein	6708381	System Analysis, Co-Developer
Han Phyo Htet	6708463	Quality Assurance, Business Analysis, Co-Tester
Nyan Lin Htet	6708397	Technical Engineer, Tester

3.2 Functional Requirements

Priority is M (must), S (should) or C (could). All are implemented.

Data acquisition

ID	Requirement	Pri
FR-01	Retrieve live aircraft positions from an external source	M
FR-02	Merge two aircraft sources, preferring the fresher record	S
FR-03	Compute satellite positions from orbital elements	M
FR-04	Refuse orbital elements older than seven days	M
FR-05	Retrieve ship positions from a regional and a global source	S
FR-06	Merge ship sources so a field is never overwritten by a blank	M
FR-07	Poll each source on a schedule within its rate limit	M
FR-08	Retain the last successful snapshot when a source fails	M
FR-09	Evict objects not re-observed within a per-layer TTL	M
FR-10	Run entirely offline from fixture data	M

API

ID	Requirement	Pri
FR-11	List objects of a layer, filtered by bounding box	M
FR-12	Return one object in full, with its observed track	M
FR-13	Search a layer by name or identifier	M
FR-14	Search all four kinds in one request	S
FR-15	Reduce results to a maximum, spread across the visible area	M
FR-16	Answer 304 when the client holds the current representation	S
FR-17	Report ingestion health and data freshness	M
FR-18	Never call an external service while handling a request	M
FR-19	Refuse malformed input with a precise error	M
FR-20	Clamp a requested result count to the configured maximum	M

Presentation

ID	Requirement	Pri
FR-21	Draw an interactive Earth, globe to street level	M
FR-22	Draw each object oriented to its heading	M

FR-23	Draw an unknown heading without implying one	M
FR-24	Fade an object older than two minutes	M
FR-25	Interpolate positions between polls	M
FR-26	Switch between the three layers	M
FR-27	Change all surrounding text and the key with the layer	M
FR-28	Select an object and show its details	M
FR-29	Draw the observed track of the selected object	M
FR-30	Draw the selected aircraft as a 3D airframe	C
FR-31	Show receiver coverage	S
FR-32	Offer a solar system view with navigable planets	C
FR-33	Colour each layer by the property that varies within it	M

Accounts and entitlements

ID	Requirement	Pri
FR-34	Register with an email and a password of at least 10 characters	M
FR-35	Sign in and out; maintain a session across reloads	M
FR-36	Hash passwords; never store them in plain text	M
FR-37	View satellite positions at a past instant	S
FR-38	Limit the window by tier: 24 hours free, 7 days premium	M
FR-39	Refuse a request outside the window with a stated reason	M
FR-40	Allow an account to change its own tier between free and premium	S
FR-41	Refuse the administrator tier from the public interface	M
FR-42	Show advertisements to accounts that are not premium	S

The premium window is seven days because that is where propagation accuracy becomes untrustworthy. No tier can exceed it.

3.3 Non-Functional Requirements

Performance

ID	Requirement	Target	Measured
NFR-01	Marker rendering at the cap	< 16.7 ms	0.80 ms at 2,000 markers
NFR-02	Sustained frame time under load	60 fps	4.2 ms p50, 5.9 ms p99
NFR-03	List endpoint response	< 100 ms	23 ms
NFR-04	Combined search response	< 100 ms	47 ms
NFR-	Detail lookup	< 10 ms	0.01 ms

05

NFR-06	Responses compressed	—	366 KB to 24.5 KB
NFR-07	No request may block the event loop indefinitely	—	Result count clamped

Reliability

ID	Requirement
NFR-08	An upstream failure must not produce an error response
NFR-09	Data past its threshold must be flagged, not hidden
NFR-10	One source failing must not disable a multi-source layer
NFR-11	A dropped stream must reconnect without losing accumulated state
NFR-12	The system must start without credentials

Accuracy

ID	Requirement
NFR-13	A protocol's "not available" encoding must never be shown as a value
NFR-14	An object without a position is not drawn
NFR-15	An unknown heading must not be drawn as north
NFR-16	Values shown in the unit their readers use
NFR-17	Text around the map must describe the layer shown, including its limits
NFR-18	A computed position must not report an observation age
NFR-19	A physically impossible speed must be rejected

Security

ID	Requirement
NFR-20	Passwords hashed with bcrypt; never logged or returned
NFR-21	Session cookies HttpOnly and SameSite
NFR-22	Credentials read from environment or a git-ignored file
NFR-23	A configuration object must never be printed whole
NFR-24	Administrator privilege not obtainable through any public endpoint

Maintainability

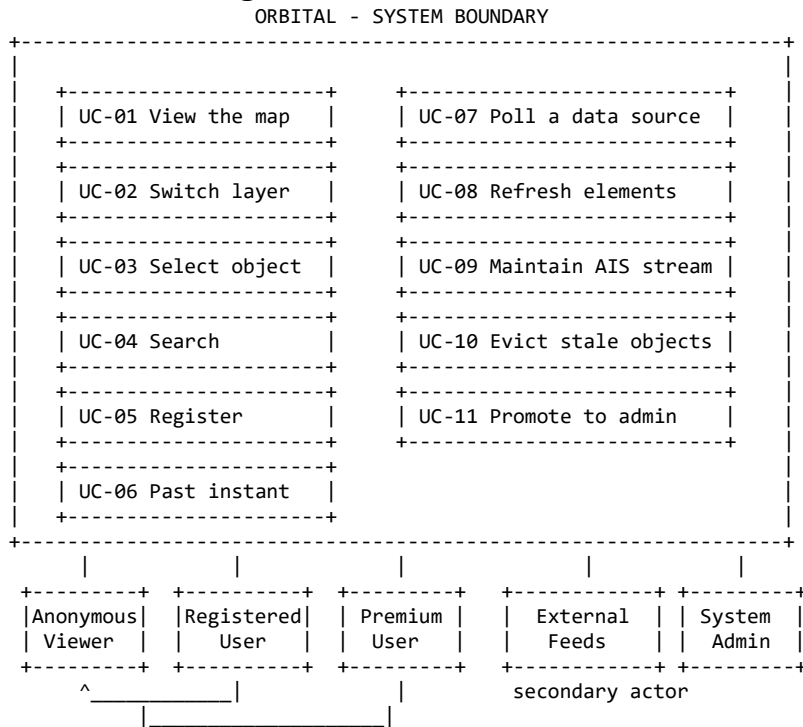
ID	Requirement	Evidence
NFR-25	One shared data shape across all layers and both languages	Kept in step by type checks
NFR-26	A new data source must not require frontend changes	Demonstrated twice
NFR-27	A new object class requires a written decision	Enforced by a test on each side

NFR-28	Every significant decision recorded	166 entries
NFR-29	Both suites runnable offline	No test makes an external call

Usability

ID	Requirement
NFR-30	Usable without an account
NFR-31	Reduced-motion preference respected
NFR-32	Controls reachable and labelled for assistive technology
NFR-33	Layout usable at a 375 px viewport

3.4 Use Case Diagram



Registered User is an Anonymous Viewer with an identity.
Premium User is a Registered User with a wider entitlement.

UC-03 includes UC-01. UC-06 extends UC-01 when an instant is chosen, if that instant lies within the actor's entitlement window. UC-07 to UC-10 are started by a scheduler rather than a person, and are shown because every external dependency and failure mode lives there.

3.5 Use Case Descriptions

UC-01 View the map

Actor Anonymous Viewer. **Preconditions** None; no account required.

1. The system draws the Earth on satellite imagery.
2. The client requests the active layer's objects for the visible area.
3. The API returns the cached snapshot, filtered and thinned, with its age.
4. The client draws each object oriented to its heading, coloured by the property that varies on that layer.
5. Between polls the client interpolates positions.

A1 Data is stale: the response is flagged, markers past two minutes fade. **A2** Backend unreachable: the last state remains; the map is not cleared. **A3** More objects than the cap: a spatially even sample is returned and both figures are reported.

UC-02 Switch layer

Actor Anonymous Viewer.

1. The viewer selects Aircraft, Satellites or Ships.
2. The system clears the current selection and objects.
3. All surrounding text changes with the layer — subtitle, search placeholder, count noun and colour key.
4. Layer-specific furniture is hidden; airports and receiver coverage belong to the aircraft layer.
5. The client polls the new layer's endpoint.

UC-03 Select an object

Actor Anonymous Viewer. **Includes** UC-01.

1. The viewer clicks a marker.
2. The client requests that object's full record.
3. A panel opens with fields appropriate to the layer.
4. The object's observed track is drawn.

A1 Empty map clicked: the selection clears. **A2** No longer tracked: a 404 is returned and the panel says so rather than showing an empty record.

UC-04 Search

Actor Anonymous Viewer.

1. The viewer types into the search box.
2. After a debounce, the client requests results.
3. Matches are returned in separate groups, ranked within each but not across them, because they are not comparable.
4. Only the groups the active layer can act on are shown.
5. Choosing a result moves the camera to it and selects it.

UC-05 Register and sign in

Actor Anonymous Viewer becoming Registered User.

1. The viewer supplies an email and password.
2. A password shorter than ten characters is rejected.
3. The password is hashed with bcrypt.
4. A session cookie is issued, HttpOnly and SameSite.

A1 Email already registered: reported without revealing the password. **A2** Wrong credentials: one message for both cases, so the response does not disclose which accounts exist.

UC-06 View a past instant

Actor Registered or Premium User. **Extends** UC-01. **Precondition** Signed in, satellite layer active.

1. The user moves the time control to a past instant.
2. The system checks it against the account's window: 24 hours free, 7 days premium.
3. Positions are propagated to that instant and returned.

A1 Outside the window: refused with the window that does apply. **A2** Beyond seven days: refused for every tier, because propagation accuracy degrades about a kilometre per day.

UC-07 Poll a data source

Actor Scheduler, with an external feed as secondary actor.

1. The scheduler waits the configured interval.
2. It checks the remaining quota and the rate gate; if either forbids, it skips.
3. The provider fetches and converts to the shared shape, discarding objects without a usable position and converting every "not available" encoding to an explicit absence.
4. The store merges the result.

A1 Unreachable: the previous snapshot is retained and the next attempt is delayed by an increasing backoff. **A2** Rate limited: the upstream's own retry hint is used. **A3** Both sources of a layer fail: only then is it an outage.

UC-08 Refresh orbital elements

1. Every six hours elements are fetched from CelesTrak.
2. Sets older than seven days from epoch are refused.
3. Accepted elements are cached to disk.

A1 CelesTrak unavailable: SatNOGS is used. If both fail, cached elements continue to serve.

UC-09 Maintain the global AIS stream

1. A WebSocket is opened and subscribed to the whole world.
2. Positions and identities are accumulated in memory.
3. Positions older than fifteen minutes are removed; identities are kept for six hours, because a vessel's name does not expire when its position does.

A1 Connection dropped: reconnection with backoff, losing nothing, because the accumulated world is held locally.

UC-11 Promote an account to administrator

Actor System Administrator at a terminal on the server.

1. The administrator runs the account tool on the host.
2. The tool sets the account's tier.

There is no interface for this and no endpoint that can perform it.

3.6 Software Requirements Specification

Purpose

This specification covers Orbital, a web application presenting live aircraft, ship and satellite positions on an interactive Earth. It defines the external interfaces, the shared data contract and the operating constraints.

System context

External feeds (six sources) -> 1. INGESTION providers, poller, store -> 2. API reads the store only -> 3. FRONTEND MapLibre and React client

Data flows in one direction, and each layer knows only the layer beneath it. Three properties follow:

1. The browser never talks to a data source, so rate limiting and caching are enforced in one place.
2. Ingestion does not know a browser exists, and the frontend does not know where the data came from.
3. Upstream failure is contained at layer 1.

User classes

Class	Access
Anonymous Viewer	Full read access, no account
Registered User	Identity, 24-hour history
Premium User	7-day history, no advertisements
Administrator	Terminal only

Constraints

Constraint	Source
OpenSky may not be used commercially	Provider terms
OpenSky spending within a daily allowance	Provider terms
adsb.lol allows 4 requests then ~1 per 12 s	Measured
Digitraffic states a 60-second cache	Provider headers
Satellite accuracy untrustworthy beyond 7 days	SGP4
The backend is a single-threaded event loop	Runtime
AIS identity arrives on a 6-minute cycle	Protocol

API

Method	Path	Purpose
GET	/api/aircraft	Aircraft in a bounding box
GET	/api/aircraft/{id}	One aircraft with track and route

GET	/api/aircraft/search	Aircraft by callsign or address
GET	/api/satellites	Satellites, optionally at a past instant
GET	/api/satellites/{id}	One satellite
GET	/api/ships	Ships in a bounding box
GET	/api/ships/{id}	One ship
GET	/api/ships/search	Ships by name or MMSI
GET	/api/search	Combined search across four kinds
GET	/api/moon/satellites	Spacecraft in lunar orbit
GET	/api/health	Ingestion status and freshness
POST	/api/auth/register	Create an account
POST	/api/auth/login	Begin a session
POST	/api/auth/logout	End a session
GET	/api/auth/me	The current account
POST	/api/auth/subscription	Change own tier

The shared data shape

Every moving object, whatever its source, is represented identically.

Field	Type	Meaning
id	string	Stable identifier within a provider
lat, lon	number	Degrees, WGS84
altitude	number or null	Metres above mean sea level; zero means zero, null means the source did not say
velocity	number or null	Metres per second
heading	number or null	Degrees clockwise from true north; null is never drawn as north
label	string	Short human-readable name
model	string or null	What the source says the object is
lastSeen	string	When the position was current, never when we polled
type	enum	aircraft, satellite or ship

Anything meaningful to only one kind of object lives in a generic meta map, so a provider can add a field without a frontend change. This is what made the second and third layers cost one module each.

Verification

Class	Method
Functional	1,842 automated tests; live runs against every real source

Performance	Instrumented measurement in the browser and a backend benchmark
Reliability	Injected outages, plus real ones that occurred unprompted
Accuracy	Unit tests on each conversion, plus inspection of the running system
Security	Tests on hashing, session handling and tier refusal

Eighteen defects are recorded as having been invisible to the tests at the time they existed, each found by running the application and looking at it. In every case the code was correct and the wiring was absent or mismatched. Unit tests verify code; only running the system verifies wiring.